

Normalized reference - Contract Management Principles and Procedures

Northern Ireland Department of Finance, Central Procurement Directorate

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Scope

Contextual government guidance on managing public contracts for goods, works and services.

Summary

The guidance treats contract management as a continuation of the procurement and award stages. Its focus is on planning, clear governance, active performance oversight and proportionate management effort based on contract risk, value and duration.

Concepts and definitions

Contract management; contract management plan; performance measures and KPIs; risk register; service continuity; change control; escalation; corrective action.

Process or procedure

Involve contract-management roles early; define governance, measures, reporting and controls; monitor delivery and supplier performance; manage changes, risks and continuity; address problems through agreed escalation and corrective procedures.

Criteria

The document points to documented roles, adequate capability and resourcing, contract-specific measures, and an approach proportionate to the contract profile.

Responsibilities

Departments retain responsibility for appropriate management; contract managers and supporting procurement functions need defined roles; suppliers are expected to meet contractual performance requirements.

Exceptions

Activities should be proportionate: lower-risk or lower-value contracts may require less intensive management. This does not remove the need for basic controls.

Risks and controls

Identify and review risks as they arise. The source highlights performance failure, continuity, financial health, conflicts of interest and delivery risk; controls include risk registers, KPIs, monitoring, escalation and continuity planning.

Questions supported

What should a contract management plan cover? What roles and controls support supplier performance? How should risks, continuity and poor performance be handled?

Limitations

Applies to the Northern Ireland public procurement context and was issued in 2017. It is institutional guidance, not universal or current legal advice.

Source sections used

Source sections 2, 3, 4, 5, 7 and 8; Annex B and Annex D.